

POR & PARA

Essential Guide

1 Core idea

First: don't translate POR and PARA word by word.

English words such as for, by, through, because of, and to can correspond to POR or PARA depending on the relationship being expressed. Start by identifying the function you need.

Important: There is no single shortcut that explains every use of POR and PARA. Cause vs. purpose is an important contrast, but other uses—such as route, means, exchange, recipient, deadline, and distribution—must be learned as functions.

2 Core Uses

ESSENTIALS

Start here. These are the everyday functions you'll need most. The columns are not perfect opposites in every row.

POR

Reason / cause

Lo felicitaron por su trabajo.

They congratulated him for his work.

Movement through / around a place

Pasamos por Puebla.

We went through Puebla.

Means / channel

Te lo mandé por WhatsApp.

I sent it to you via WhatsApp.

Exchange / price

Pagué \$200 por el libro.

I paid \$200 for the book.

Distribution

Tres manzanas por persona.

Three apples per person.

Part of the day

Estudio por la mañana.

I study in the morning.

Approximate time / date

Nos veremos por Navidad.

We'll see each other around Christmas.

Agent of a passive construction

Fue escrito por Juan.

It was written by Juan.

PARA

Purpose / goal

Salí temprano para llegar a tiempo.

I left early in order to arrive on time.

Destination / direction

Salimos para Puebla.

We left for Puebla.

Recipient / intended beneficiary

Este regalo es para Ana.

This gift is for Ana.

Deadline

Lo necesito para mañana.

I need it by tomorrow.

Intended use

Necesito zapatos para correr.

I need shoes for running.

Standard / reference point

Es alto para su edad.

He is tall for his age.

DURATION NOTE

POR can occur with duration:

Viví ahí por dos años.

In contemporary Mexican Spanish, it is often omitted:

Viví ahí dos años.

3 Cause, Reason, Motive & Purpose

This is the most important semantic contrast between POR and PARA, but the categories are not always completely separate.

The prototypical contrast

POR · cause / reason / motive

Cancelaron el vuelo por la tormenta.

The storm caused or explains the cancellation.

Lo felicitaron por su trabajo.

His work is the reason for the congratulations.

PARA · purpose / intended goal

Estudio para aprender.

Learning is the intended goal.

Salí temprano para llegar a tiempo.

Arriving on time is the intended result.

With an infinitive

POR + infinitive

The action explains or motivates something.

Gracias por venir.

Lo castigaron por llegar tarde.

PARA + infinitive

The action is presented as the intended goal.

Vine para hablar contigo.

Estudio para aprender español.

When motive and goal overlap

Real situations do not always divide neatly into cause and purpose. A desired result can also be the reason that motivates an action. Spanish may therefore allow more than one construction, with a change in perspective or structural preference.

Lucho por la libertad.

Lucho por conseguir la libertad.

Lucho para conseguir la libertad.

POR + noun is especially natural for the cause, ideal, or motive that drives an action; **PARA + infinitive** presents the intended result particularly clearly. **POR + infinitive** can also occur when the infinitive is conceptualized as the reason or motive. Treat this as a tendency and a difference in perspective, **not as an absolute formula**.

4 Movement: Route vs. Destination

POR · route / transit



Pasamos por Puebla.

We went through Puebla.

Caminamos por el centro.

We walked through / around downtown.

PARA · destination / direction



Salimos para Puebla.

We left for Puebla.

Voy para mi casa.

I'm heading home.

DESTINATION NOTE · A is also extremely common

With destinations, Spanish very commonly uses **A**: **Voy a mi casa / Salimos a Puebla**. PARA is useful when destination or direction is emphasized; it is not the only preposition used to express destination.

5 Same Words, Different Relationship

These pairs are especially useful because changing only the preposition changes how the relationship is interpreted.

POR TI vs. PARA TI

Lo hice por ti.

You were the reason or motivation; depending on context, for your sake.

Lo hice para ti.

You were the intended recipient or beneficiary.

POR MÍ vs. PARA MÍ

Por mí, está bien.

As far as I'm concerned / I don't object.

Para mí, está bien.

In my opinion, it's fine.

6 ESTAR POR / ESTAR PARA

ESTAR POR + infinitive

This construction has more than one productive interpretation. Its meaning depends on context and on the infinitive.

Pending / remaining to be done

La tarea está por hacerse.

The homework remains to be done.

Intention / imminence

Estoy por salir.

I'm about to leave / I'm on the point of leaving.

Context-dependent uses

La tarea está por terminarse.

Can describe a task close to being finished; the exact English rendering depends on context.

Common expression

Está por verse.

It remains to be seen.

ESTAR PARA + infinitive / noun

This construction can express readiness, suitability, condition, or disposition for an action. It also appears in common idiomatic evaluations.

No estoy para discutir.

I'm not in the mood / condition to argue.

No estoy para bromas.

I'm not in the mood for jokes.

Está para chuparse los dedos.

It's delicious. [Idiomatic expression]

7 Quick Reference

Already familiar with the patterns? Use this as a quick reminder.

This is a reference table, not a universal decision algorithm.

POR

Cause / reason / motive

Route / movement through

Means / channel

Exchange / price

Distribution

Part of the day

Approximate time / date

Agent of passive construction

PARA

Purpose / goal

Destination / direction

Recipient / beneficiary

Deadline

Intended use

Standard / reference point